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MOVEMENT SYSTEM 08

The Desk-Job Mobility Plan

Ten minutes a day to undo nine hours of sitting. For the neck, the lower back, the hips and the shoulders that a laptop has slowly rearranged.

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What nine hours of sitting actually does

Nothing dramatic happens on any single day. Over three years, a laptop and a chair rotate your shoulders forward, shorten your hip flexors, switch your glutes off, and load your neck with the weight of a bowling ball held out in front of you.

Area	What happens	What you feel
Neck	Head drifts forward; every 2.5 cm forward adds ~4.5 kg of load	Stiffness at the base of the skull, tension headaches
Upper back	Thoracic spine loses rotation and extension	Rounded posture, tight shoulders, can't press overhead
Hips	Hip flexors shorten, glutes go dormant	Tight hips, aching lower back, weak squats
Lower back	Compensates for everything above and below it	The 4pm ache, worse on long-flight days
Wrists	Held in extension all day	Tingling, forearm fatigue

THE REAL FIX

Stretching does less than most people hope. What actually works is **frequency of position change**. The ten-minute routine below matters, but the two-minute break every hour matters more. Set an hourly reminder today.

Fix the setup first

- **Screen top at eye level.** A laptop on a desk guarantees neck flexion. Use a stand or a stack of books plus an external keyboard. This is the highest-impact change on the page.
- **Elbows at 90°**, forearms supported, shoulders down.
- **Feet flat**, knees at 90°. Use a footrest if your chair is too high.
- **Sit back into the chair.** The lumbar support only works if your back is touching it.

The daily ten minutes

Do this once a day — before the shower or in the evening. Eight movements, no equipment, no floor mat required.

Block 1 — Open the front (4 min)

Movement	Dose	How
Couch stretch / kneeling hip flexor	60 sec per side	Back knee down, squeeze the glute of the back leg, tuck the tailbone. You should feel it in the front of the hip, not the lower back.
Doorway pec stretch	45 sec per side	Forearm on the frame at shoulder height, step through, turn away from the arm.
Deep squat hold	60 sec	Heels down, elbows inside knees, chest up. Hold a doorframe if needed.

Block 2 — Restore rotation (3 min)

Movement	Dose	How
Open book	8 per side	Side-lying, knees bent, top arm sweeps across the body. Follow the hand with your eyes.
Cat-cow	10 slow reps	Move one vertebra at a time, don't rush it
Thread the needle	6 per side	From all fours, reach one arm under the body

Block 3 — Switch things back on (3 min)

Movement	Dose	How
Glute bridge	15 reps, 2 sec hold at top	Squeeze at the top. Ribs down, don't arch.
Wall slide	12 reps	Back, head and arms against wall, slide arms up without losing contact
Chin tuck	10 × 5 sec	Make a double chin, hold. Undoes forward head posture.
Band pull-apart	20 reps	The single best anti-desk exercise there is

The hourly two minutes

This is the part that actually changes how your back feels by Friday. Set a recurring reminder. Do it at your desk — nobody will notice.

Stand and reset (60 sec)

Stand up. Ten chin tucks. Roll the shoulders back five times. Reach both arms overhead and lean gently to each side.

Move (60 sec)

Walk to the water cooler, take the long route. Ten bodyweight squats if you have privacy. Two flights of stairs if you don't.

Build it into the day

Trigger	Action
Every call you don't need to screen-share on	Take it standing or walking
Every time you refill water	Ten shoulder rolls on the way back
Between back-to-back meetings	Two minutes: stand, chin tucks, doorway pec stretch
Waiting for a build / report / deploy	Deep squat hold, 60 seconds
Long flight or car journey	Stand and walk every 60 minutes; couch stretch on arrival

WHEN TO SEE A PHYSIO, NOT A PDF

Pain radiating down a leg or arm, numbness or tingling that doesn't settle, weakness in a limb, or back pain that wakes you at night. Those are not mobility problems. Get them assessed properly.

What to expect

- **Week 1:** the deep squat hold is uncomfortable and your hips complain. Normal.
- **Week 2–3:** the 4pm lower-back ache noticeably reduces.
- **Week 4:** overhead reach improves, neck tension drops, and your gym lifts feel better — especially pressing and squatting.

- ☐ Screen raised to eye level
- ☐ Hourly movement reminder set on the phone
- ☐ Resistance band kept at the desk
- ☐ Ten-minute routine attached to an existing daily habit

The compounding argument

Ten minutes a day is 60 hours a year. Against 2,000 hours of sitting it sounds hopeless — except the sitting damage isn't from the hours, it's from the *lack of interruption*. You're not out-stretching the chair. You're just refusing to let one position set.